EL

written by

Anthony Padavano

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Fifth Draft

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Prescription bottle’s top slides, its safety clicks open, the top pops off.

At the bottom of the bottle: a long and deep blackhole.

A distant heart rate monitor chirps at 70 BPM...

Chirping quicker, and ramping up to 120 BPM as the sound draws near--

Spotlight clicks on, ignites a sterile blue wall:

A slender, hairless, and cocked arm fades in fighting an invisible force for its life a few brief moments before cranking open like a drawbridge.

At the other end of the light blue wall, a butterfly needle creeps down the wall, freezes, then darts with the speed of light into the crook of the tensed arm.

White wall tiles fade in, followed by a mirror on the wall--then the standup shower behind the disembodied arm, and the rest of the

INT. BATHROOM - MORNING

The arm turns music on from its smartphone.Aggressive female vocals scream over an incessant two chord progression.

In the shower, the arm, attached to a translucent humanoid body, lets the water beat on its back.

Behind it, a heavenly light opens and swallows the room for an instant. The translucent head turns to see...it wipes away the fog from the shower glass--

Missed it. On the counter, propped up against the wall , the blank smartphone’s screen reflects the figure looking from the shower.

Patting itself dry: the arm and a chestnut skin-toned, albeit feature-less body.

It slips on over its head a sports bra, then a yellow t-shirt, and slides on jean shorts (referred to further as ‘the uniform,’ or ‘her uniform’).

The bathroom door busts out of its frame with the succession of three loud and hard knocks.

Indiscriminate screaming follows.

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EL's (16) shoulder-length, pin-straight, black, and wet hair, zip to the other end of her shoulder as her head swings toward the door.

Her full body contorts as she screams without making a sound.

She grabs her phone from the counter, lowers the music a few notches--discovers the source of the notification from before.

A confused eyebrow-lift dives into a smile.

With the music back to its original volume, El dances in the bathroom, loading her toothbrush with paste, and brushes her teeth with vigor.

Her eyes jump up and down within the mirror, the pupils grow larger and larger until they take up her whole eye and the black spills down her cheeks.

She dabs the running black off of her face, and gives a smile and thumbs up to the mirror.

LIVING ROOM

The morning sun fights through fast moving clouds and swinging, thick window blinds.

El, deflated, slouches on the right-most cushion of the three cushioned couch, her smartphone in her hands.

A squirm works its way through her, then disappears.

Vines (of all different shapes and sizes) crawl out from underneath the darkness of the couch, and wrap their tendrils around El's ankles.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Dave got fired.

DAVE (O.S.)
Dave got let go.

Across from El, on two almost touching love seats sit two almost touching adults, SANDRA (40s) and DAVE (40s). Both are considerably fairer in skin than El. Sandra dons business casual wear; and Dave...well, Dave is still in his pajamas.

Sandra shoots Dave a look of disapproval. A very very very...very tired look.

Very tired.

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DAVE
There’s a difference.

SANDRA
I didn’t realize that Publix started offering severance packages.

Dave answers with no answer and a sip from a mug (large enough to cover his entire face) of way too hot coffee.

SANDRA
The point is. We’re taking you out of private school...We think...

The vines wrap around her calfs, then clutch her knees. She swipes at her knees, aggravating them further.

DAVE (O.S.)
We don’t want to.

SANDRA (O.S.)
No--

Dave avoids eye contact with El.

DAVE
Not at all.
(Getting choked up)
It breaks my heart.

SANDRA
(rolling eyes)
Sure...And while we’re pulling off band aids, fact is that it’s been a long time coming. You’re always leaving school early. Missing assignments, and quizzes, and tests. How do you think that reflects upon me?

DAVE
(fool’s redirection)
Plus! Dave got fir--let go!

Sandra moves an empty wine glass off the coffee table, lays down her briefcase, cracks it, and hands El a high-school information pamphlet

El leans forward to grab it, but the vines have latched her down onto the couch. She sticks out her arm--

Sandra leans a bit closer to bridge the gap.

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SANDRA
That's where you'll be going in Spring.

El opens the pamphlet, and scans the panels.

Sandra clears her throat loudly.

Dave, oblivious and still emotional, takes another sip from his coffee.

SANDRA
Dave?

DAVE
Ah, yeah. Er. Uh--also--you're sixteen now. As you know. And your mom--Sandra...it's the minimum wage age. So, well.

Sandra opens the briefcase, both sides now flat on the table.

She reaches both of her arms into the briefcase, and digs deeper and deeper, until the briefcase nearly swallows her entire torso.

Gulp...

A leaning tower of a manilla folder comes barging out of the briefcase, and Sandra dumps it upon Dave's lap.

Sandra procures another similar stack, dropping it right near her chair. She sits and readjusts herself, taking a breath.

The vines secure El's waist to the couch, and crawl further up toward her chest.

DAVE (O.S.)
Me and your--Sandra--put together a list of options.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Sensitive to your problem--

DAVE (O.S.)
Condition.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Condition. Right.

Sandra pushes bifocals up the bridges of her nose, she waits while Dave struggles with his bifocals he pulls out from within his worn robes.

They collectively center themselves before--

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Opening the folders, papers zip out whacking the ceiling and spilling out onto the floor.

The papers swarm around their heads, little dive bombers on suicide missions.

Sandra and Dave frantically sort through the papers, grabbing at them, then throwing them free, trying to find something--

Anything!

They start to scream options off of randomly grabbed pieces of paper:

SANDRA
Babysitter!

DAVE
She is responsible. But that'd be hard for her, I bet.

SANDRA
Offer constructive criticism-- defeatist!

DAVE
Paper Boy!

Sandra winces.

DAVE
Paper girl!

SANDRA
Paper person.

DAVE
(stumbling over each word)
Lawn. Care. Helper. Technician.

The vines wrap around El's throat, and crawl up her cheeks.

SANDRA (O.S.)
No. Ugh!...grocery bagger?

DAVE (O.S.)
With the same people who fired me?

SANDRA (O.S.)
I thought you got laid off?

The vines probe El's mouth, then force the jaw open to crawl down her throat, choking her.

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Her fingers grip the sofa, digging into the fabric, and then tearing through to the cushion underneath.

As Sandra and Dave bicker, the paper swarm overtakes the apartment--a white snowy feedback: the two of them distant shadows.

Their argument grows dull and fades as a rising sound of

barking dogs

comes to overpower everything.

EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - MORNING

As El shuts the front door:

DAVE (O.S.)
Have a good day and be--

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - PARKING LOT

GARY (30s), battles the power of his leashed pit bull, JOJO, as it tries to break free and feast on a huddle of four migrant workers surrounding a pickup truck.

Gary yells at the migrants in Spanish.

El, on the far end of the parking lot, sneaks by the scene, but as she passes--

Jojo sniffs her out, and his attention turns to her, pulling Gary in the opposite direction.

Two of the migrants turn on another one, they grab him and force him down onto his knees.

The kneeled migrant prays for his life.

Without turning to look at Jojo's distraction, Gary yanks hard on Jojo's leash, and barks a command which course corrects Jojo.

Gary lets Jojo go, and he leaps at the poor praying migrant.

El spins on her heels, and hustles in the opposite direction--

Her phone dings. As she keeps walking, she flips her backpack around to her front, unzips, and pulls the phone out--

A car backing out of its parking spot catches her leg and almost swallows her whole.

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She bangs on the car--it screeches to a halt!

El crawls out from underneath the trunk, and walks over to the driver's door.

Sandra texting on her phone behind the wheel. She blows El off, continues backing out, then off toward the exit.

The sound of successive car alarms grows louder.

A red race-car careens into the parking lot,

just about to collide with a distracted Sandra--

misses Sandra a millisecond before the high impact collision,

spinning out and on, burning and ripping rubber past and beyond El. The bass from the red race-car sets off every car alarm it passes.

It spins and parks, the passenger suicide-door lifts open, and heavenly light emanates from within the vehicle.

The sound turns off and time slows down as the haloed SHEEN (20s), a young woman of casual and effortless style,

gets out of the car and

adjusts the length of her dress.

Sound and time ramp up, Sheen's screaming her head-off as she walks off to ascend a flight of stairs.

FRANK (20s), donning a red leather outfit complete with a face-hiding helmetred, barrels out of the car after her, but she bares him no mind.

He halts before following her up to the second floor, flails his arms in exasperation, then retreats to his car.

He gets in through the already open passenger side, and struggles with closing the suicide-door.

El continues on her way toward the street.

Frank tails her, crawling a few car lengths behind.

DISSOLVE TO:

RESIDENTIAL STREET

El hurries down the street. Behind her Frank turns into view.

DISSOLVE TO:

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BUSY STREET

El runs down the street.

Frank turns following her still.

She arrives at the bus stop the same time as the bus and hops on.

INT. BUS

El watches Frank follow her from the rear. He holds up his smartphone to the window and towards El.

He jams the breaks and goes down a different road.

EXT. SCHOOL

Frank pulls up, u-turns, and parks across the street. All the Senior’s car alarms whine.

The bus pulls up, eclipsing his car.

Bus pulls away,

Frank's next to El, smartphone up in hand, recording her.

El bounds toward the building. He’s screaming muffled words at her as he follows her towards the school, up the stairs.

INT. SCHOOL

El opens the front door, and slams it closed behind her as the sound of the car alarms and the uproarious engine crescendo.

She slides to the floor, breathing heavy.

DISSOLVE TO:

A.M. HOMEROOM

As El enters Homeroom, the bell rings.

El fights her way into the room as the kids pour out.

She then fights for the attention of the HOMEROOM TEACHER ignoring her.

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HR TEACHER
(annoyed)
You're late. Go to the office. Get a late pass. Again...

SCHOOL OFFICE

El stands before a large desk, an ELDERLY ASSISTANT fills out a late-pass behind said desk.

ELDERLY ASSIST.
Late two mods. Two days detention.
(Finishing up the late-pass)
Detention's in room--
(hands over the late-pass, and makes eye contact)
I don't need to tell <u>you</u> the details, now do I, missy?

CLASSROOM

El enters, disrupting the class, and freezes.

HISTORY TEACHER
Well?

El hands over her late-pass to the MATH TEACHER, then takes her seat in the class.

She unpacks her bag, pulls out her textbook and a notebook, a few drawing pencils, and an eraser.

HISTORY TEACHER (30s) writes some notes on the board, narrating as they do so. The repeating chalk screeches cause all the students to wince.

El doodles a fast and furious impression of Sheen in the notebook.

The H.T. looms behind her, before whacking the desk with a long ruler.

HISTORY TEACHER (O.S.)
No doodling in class! This is history!

WISE ASS
And her story!

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GUIDANCE COUNSELOR'S OFFICE

El sits stiff on a chaise lounge.

Behind her two glowing red eyes surrounded by utter darkness.

COUNSELOR
Are you here today to break your streak?

El pulls out a deck of prewritten cards from her jean short pocket, shuffles through them, settles on one, then holds the card up behind her for the red eyes.

COUNSELOR
I see.

El sits in a long silence.

Shuffles the cards, searching again.

COUNSELOR
I see. Would you like to tell us why you are here then?

El reaches on the floor below her, and retrieves a notepad and marker.

As she's writing:

COUNSELOR
I suppose you're here to waste our time and taxpayers money. You are dismissed.

Two faceless armed guards in riot gear grab El from under the armpits, and throw her out of the Counselor's office.

EXT. PLAYGROUND - AFTERNOON

El fiddles with the Sheen sketch.

Then furiously scribbles over the whole work,

blacking it out.

She wipes her wetted eyes. And pauses the music playing through her earbuds.

A dog barks. She looks away from her work.

In the distance, a cheer squad practices on the sidelines of a football field, while players run drills on the field.

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Not so far away, girls versus boys volleyball game picks up fire.

A much closer dog bark draws El's attention towards a dog and its walker, strolling along the perimeter of the school yard.

As she stares, the pencil dashes around on her drawing pad. She never looks down.

A volleyball with spikes whacks El in the head--

Her sketchpad and smartphone go flying, ripcording her earbuds out, and knocking her hard agains the metal fence behind her.

MIA (16) and her posse, BACKUP BITCH 1-4, approach. All the Backup Bitches are revved up, except one. EMILY (16) hovers behind the other three. They're all dressed in similarly altered to-be-more-revealing uniforms.

MIA
Ugh! How clumsy!

EXT. BEACH - VOLLEYBALL COURT

El digs her sketchbook out from a mound of sand.

She then digs around for her smartphone, finds it, pulling out thirty feet of headphone cable from an endless sand hole.

Red with anger she shoves her stuff into her backpack.

The bullies stand on one side of the net, arms folded in front and hips cocked. Except Emily, she slumps.

MIA
I said! "Whoops, that was an accident!" Didn't you hear me? I said <u>sorry</u>. That was a... <u>accident</u>.

BACKUP BITCH 2
Did you hear her?

BACKUP BITCH 3
She said sorry.

A crowd of teens all dressed in summer beach wear approach and surround the court. They cheer at the prospect of a tense battle.

El's knees lock, her anger turns cold, as the circus spins around her.

The crowd tosses into the court another spiky volleyball.

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Backup Bitch 2 picks it up, and sets it up for Mia to serve.

Mia spikes it, and it almost hits El, but she moves just in time, throwing herself into the sand, and getting a mouthful.

MIA
Dumb and deaf.

Backup Bitches 2-4 laugh.

MIA
You hear me, Em? I said she was "dumb and deaf."

EMILY
(sotto voce)
Yeah. Deaf and dumb.

Emily pushes through the crowd and leaves.

MIA
Em?...Em?!

Backup Bitches 2-4 chant "Dumb and deaf!"

El regains her composure, and on the verge of tears also pushes through the crowd surrounding them.

EXT. SCHOOLYARD

Breaking through the thirty-person-thick wall of onlookers,

El wipes tears from her face,

then hurries down the street,

before re-entering the school.

INT. SCHOOL

El sneaks past another Faceless Security Guard pre-occupied on his smartphone.

She slips into a stairwell, up two flights of stairs, down the hall, and stops in front of the door to the school's library and computer lab.

El pulls on the door. It's locked.

The computer teacher, MS. ROGER (a lady older than any computer), comes to the door. She has a napkin tucked into her shirt.

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ROGER
(chewing)
What do you want? It's lunchtime.

EL drops to her knee, wrestles her Bio textbook from her bag, and shows it to Ms. Roger.

ROGER
Oh, you're the one who don't talk. For chrissakes, every single one of you has a problem.

Ms. Roger moves out of the way, allowing El to enter.

INT. LIBRARY/COMPUTER LAB

El finds a computer seat out of eyesight of Ms. Roger.

ROGER (O.S.)
Remember, no printing! Not in the budget.

She opens up her sketchbook, pours sand out of it, then makes a few adjustments to what is now a dog walker flyer.

El peeks around a colossal ancient PC, and sees Roger looking right at her.

She recoils, and hides.

El ponders.

She scribbles a note down in her sketchpad, rips it out carefully,

scribbles another note, rips it again,

and scribbles.

El delivers one note to Roger, her sketchbook hidden behind her back.

ROGER
Yes?
(Pulls her glass off)
...this is in the backroom...this is my lunch break too!

And with that Roger huffs off to the backroom.

El runs around the desk,

plants the proper sketch page firmly down on the scanner,

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and fires-off a few copies.

As copies print, El keeps watch.

In the midst of the fourth rendering, El hears Roger coming back and is unable to cancel the print-job. She rips the power cord out of the wall.

The printer halts as Roger returns, book in hand.

Roger hands El the book. El feigns disappointment.

ROGER
That is the exact book you asked for.

EL hands Roger note numero dos.

Beat.

Roger turns on her heels back to the rumored backroom.

El tugs on Roger's shirtsleeve, and hands her four more crumpled notes, one

at

a

time.

Roger snatches the pencil from El's hand and snaps it in half before storming off to the backroom.

El plugs the printer back in.

It starts up and continues printing.

She watches a few more copies print.

Behind her, Roger clears her throat. El slowly turns around trying to slam the "cancel print" button

but the printer just keeps on printing,

And printing

and...

The print job ends, El reaches behind her to grab the flyers from the tray,

and then runs off to collect her stuff.

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EXT. STREET

El hurries down a low-traffic road, the school in the distance

A strong gust flaps and folds the flyers in on themselves as El tries to count how many she printed.

1...2...3 (first distorted flyer of the bunch)...
4...5...6...7...8.

El tosses the flyers in a bin she passes as she makes a turn onto a

CONGESTED STREET

Head down, she continues her trek.

She reaches the far end of the street before having to cross over the lane.

Waiting for the signal to walk, she turns her head skyward.

In the distance, a pillar of smoke billows towards the heavens.

Soon the smoke will meet the Northbound march of an incoming Florida rain storm.

Emergency vehicles head for the smoke and the storm. All other vehicles drive in the opposite direction.

El backpedals down the congested street.

BUS STOP

Outside a bunch of store fronts, Sheen takes cover from the heavy rain.

El joins her, albeit far away, the retrieved flyers hidden under her shirt.

As El notices Sheen the rain freezes in place. And everything quiets...

Sheen, falls against a filthy wall,

takes a bite of her buttered roll,

chews...

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stops chewing, lulls off the wall, jerks awake,

chews quicker than before,

hard swallow,

gulp...

coughs,

spits out a loogie--

The rip-roaring bus pulls up with hyper speed, blowing all the flyers out of El's hands.

She tries to chase them in the wind tunnel,

grabs one,

the rest land on the soaking wet floor.

INT. BUS

El opens a little pouch on her bag with the exact change and dumps it into the dispenser.

OLD-MAN (O.S.)
You think your wife is bad come over to my house! Okay? Me and you, we'll switch. Okay?

HUGH (70s) in bald, pudgy, shrunken spine, high-waisted slacks, sits up front amongst his groceries (taking up the seats on either side of him).

El hurries to a seat near the back, equal distance between Sheen (far back) and Hugh (right up front next to the driver).

As the bus takes off:

BUS DRIVER
(screaming at Hugh)
Sir, will you please shut up!?

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HUGH
What?!

BUS DRIVER
Would you--
(composing himself)
keepitdownplease?

HUGH
I sure would mind! I've been quieted enough in my life! We've been quieted enough! Our people. My people!

Hugh quiets down and becomes one with his groceries.

El straightens out her flyer--

it's the one the printer messed up. But it's still legible.

She folds the last flyer carefully, and tucks it away into her bag.

El steals quick glances of Sheen in the back, sketching her again in her sketchbook.

Sheen nods off, one earbud in the other falls out. She comes to, puts the other earbud back in and rocks-out for a few measures.

El develops the right proportions of her Sheen sketch, some finer details. The nape of her neck.

HUGH (O.S.)
(getting louder)
You!...You!...Hey! You!!!

El turns and he's pointing right at her.

HUGH
Come on and sit over here. Don't make me scream across the bus for you, sweetie.

El looks every way but his, evading his eye lock.

HUGH
(waving her over)
Come on.

El moves a few seats closer.

HUGH
Closer. Closer.
(MORE)

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HUGH (CONT'D)
(whispering, but not at all)
They don't like Jews talking on this bus. Can you believe it? Silencing me? How times have changed. So sad.
(normal volume a.k.a. very loud)
I said closer.

She slides over a few seats, now spitting distance.

HUGH
Did you know that there was a time, not too long ago mind you, when Jews weren't allowed into Disney. I swore to myself, as a father and a Jew, no matter which way or which how that I'd take my girls to Disney.
(reaches into a pocket, pulls out a prescription bottle)
If I had any boys, of course, I would've taken them too. The point is...there was a time when kids would play outside.
(opens the bottle, pops one in his mouth, and chews it)
Open fire-hydrants and play baseball with sticks and then kneel on those same sticks if we didn't make out beds right. Real discipline...

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - AFTERNOON

The sun shines bright once again. El, carrying all the grocery bags, and Hugh, her flyer in hand, make their way toward his apartment, and up a flight of stairs.

HUGH
...our nephew trains police sniffing dogs, you know...Why is the letters so small...The point is, live and let live, but don't take it out of our paychecks. I'm not paying taxes so Joe Shmo can go and get his rocks off. Listen, the point is this...
(MORE)

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HUGH (CONT'D)
This is my point, and I've been saying this to the girls since they were old enough to hear...

Hugh hands her back the crumpled last flyer,

she shifts all the bags from one hand to the other,

takes the flyer back, and stuffs it into her pocket, crumpling it further.

El almost drops a bag as she readjusts.

HUGH
(unlocking the door)
Careful! Careful! For chrissakes...if you squish that liverwurst she'll kill you. And I won't hear the end of it. Can't wait for that stupid dog to croak.
(he sticks out his expecting hands, wiggling his finger)
Now gimme here.

Hugh slams the door on El's face.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

El closes the door, slides down it onto the floor.

DAVE (O.S.)
Honey? Home already?

Tension returns.

Texts Dave: "Half day."

DAVE (O.S.)
Lot of half days this year, huh? Must be making budget cuts.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MAILBOX BAY - AFTERNOON

El flattens out the last remaining distorted flyer agains the side of a large free-standing mailbox.

Faint voices grow louder.

MYLO (late teens), in fancy athletic sweatsuit, approaches with a young Mister and Missus Shady couple in tow.

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El tapes the flyer down, real good.

Mylo doesn't notice El.

MYLO (O.S.)
...drop like flies around here. It's crazy. Honestly. On one hand, sucks for them. On the other, all these better and better apartments keep opening up. Eighteen hundred for two bedrooms. Fifteen for one bedroom. Me and my brothers, we mind our business and we mind our own goddamned business. You know what I--

They walk right by her, Mylo pauses, backpedals.

MYLO
Yo! Pretty child, what do you think you are doing?
(moves closer)
No advertising no soliciting without approval from the eye...
(points to one camera, then hisses:)
ssssssssssssssssssssss
(grabs El by the scalp to make her see all the other cameras)
in the sky.

Mylo rips her last flyer off the mailbox. Shred by shred.

RipRipRipRipRips the flyer into a million little pieces.

MYLO
Got it?

He throws them into the air above her. Paper shreds rains down on El.

High-fives the Mister and Missus Shade, and carries on, laughing.

MYLO (O.S.)
So as like I was saying...We mind our own goddamn business.

El takes a knee, and tries to reassemble the once distorted and now shredded and distorted flyer.

All but one piece missing--

Wind yanks away a few pieces.

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SHARON (40s), in scrubs, smoking a cigarette, head down, occupied by her cellphone, knocks into a crouched El.

SHARON
Watch where you're going!
(recognizing El)
What're you doing on the floor?!

As El topples, final shreds of the flyer lift off with a single and final gust, flying into the sky up up above.

SHARON
Are you...having a fit?

El writes on her palm with marker.

El stands up, spins around--

She holds up her hand in front of her face, blocking her view of Sharon.

SHARON
(walking away)
How'd I'd kill to come home from work and not have to walk a damned dog...what a fantasy. Imagine? Let me tell you something, sweetie...
(she looks for El, catching up)
...men, better yet, boys--don't grow up. No matter what age they won't walk the dog.

EXT. SHARON'S APARTMENT

They halt in front of Sharon's front door.

Sharon touches El's cheek, she gets cute and mousey.

SHARON
Just to prove old Sharon knows what she is talking about...if I go inside and he didn't walk the dog....

Sharon goes inside her apartment, and smiles as she closes the front door.

Beat.

Bark.

Muffled screams of a banshee blow the roof off the entire apartment complex.

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Everything settles.

Door opens.

Sharon, cigarette in mouth, martini in hand, stands behind the threshold.

SHARON
Congratulations!

She slams the door closed--

Then re-opens it very quietly.

Sharon sticks out a long manicured finger, beckoning El closer and El of course obliges.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - LATE AFTERNOON

El celebrates in the courtyard. Voices nearby grab her attention.

OMAR (20) and MICAH (20), two skinny college dudes in loose cargo shorts and oversized collared shirts, sharing a joint, enter from the parking lot.

El straightens up, puffs up her chest, and makes moves towards them.

As they draw closer, El waves to try and get their attention. They're preoccupied, however.

Before they meet, the boys hang a turn, and head up a flight of stairs.

El tails them.

OMAR
Not true.

MICAH
True. Very true.

OMAR
Prove it.

MICAH
Someone's phone has all the evidence I need.

OMAR
Someone. Not you.

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MICAH
Listen, it's your bad you suck at F.P.S.s and drinking and getting Lee's number when she was practically begging for you to ask.

El jumps up and down behind them.

OMAR
You're dumb.

MICAH
Why?

OMAR
Because you are.

MICAH
Solid argument.

OMAR
As solid as you're evidence.

El reaches for a sleeve--

MICAH
Funny.

Misses.

OMAR
You're funny.

MICAH
You're way funnier.

Micah stomps out the joint, simultaneously Omar pulls out some wraps to roll another one.

EXT. COLLEGE KID'S DORM

All three arrive at the front door, El remains unnoticed as they continue their work. Micah fills the joint wrap with weed for Omar to roll.

OMAR
Let's ask Zoe.

MICAH
Good. Yeah. Best idea you had all day. I'll ask Zoe.

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OMAR
I'll ask Zoe.

MICAH
Dude. I'll ask Zoe.

OMAR
Open the door.

MICAH
You don't have your key?

OMAR
(licking the wrap)
I do. I'm a little busy, asshole.

MICAH
What pocket?

Micah starts to pat his pockets,

he dips a hand--

Omar recoils.

OMAR
(finishes joint)
Chill.
(finding his key)
And.
(unlocks the door)
I'm...
(opens the door)
asking Zoe.

Micah chases Omar in, leaving the door wide open and El standing their left behind.

BO, a young golden retriever, stares at her frozen inside.

El hesitates, then reaches in and close the door herself.

Knock. Knock.

ZOE (early 20s) answers. Bubbly and annoyed at the boys arguing somewhere in the apartment.

ZOE
Hi!?

El waves, matching the bubblyness.

Beat.

Made in Highland

ZOE
So...what's up?
(to the boys inside)
Shut up! You're both idiots--thus, you're both wrong!
(to El)
Sorry about that...
(beat)
So...what <u>is</u> up?

El holds out her hand, but the marker is smudged and unreadable.

El whips out her deck of cards, shuffles through them, and hands over one to Zoe.

Zoe starts saying her phone number--

El a few beats behind, grabs her phone, so Zoe starts from the beginning but more slowly this time.

Zoe twirls her hair in confusion as

El texts her.

El starts to act out the text as Zoe reads it.

Zoe looks back, and Bo stands frozen in the same spot.

ZOE
Oh my god. If this dog needs anything it's a walk that lasts longer than the trot from the food bowl to his bed.

Excitement swells. The second sale.

ZOE
Problem is, he's not really my dog.

El gestures to the boys inside.

ZOE
God, you think they're capable of taking care of an animal? Another guy. We don't get along, and I don't think he'd be interested. Sorry.

El waves, a crumpled mouth, then shrugs off.

ZOE (O.S.)
Listen...tell ya' what.
(MORE)

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ZOE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
If you can do this before seven every night, I could pay you.

El returns smiling.

ZOE
I mean, the poor thing rots all day. Text me before you're gonna swing by though.

El gives a thumbs up, backing away. Zoe closes the door.

EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT - LATE AFTERNOON

El comes dancing and hopping past the door.

Backpedals and returns composed.

Leaves.

Returns. Raises a fist to knock...

Leaves again--

Comes back, hand over eyes, the other hand finally

knocks. Breathing heavily before regaining composure once more.

No one answers the door.

El kicks her sneakered feet into the ground. Fidgets with her cuticles.

She gives up and leaves.

Door opens every so slowly and pillars of smoke escape.

El hurries back and greets Sheen at the door.

SHEEN
Hey, little chick. Where'd'ya go.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. EL'S BEDROOM

El, lying stomach down on her bed, her face inches away from the paper, adds some finishing touches on her Sheen sketch.

She pulls her face away, and admires her rendering.

Made in Highland

INT. KITCHEN - EVENING

Dave, wearing an apron over his pajamas, a plate of food and his coffee mug in his hands, approaches Sandra at the dinner table. Same outfit from this morning, but with a few buttons undone.

He struggles to place a plate of food down amongst mountains of student papers in front of Sandra...

SANDRA
Bravo. Not microwave.
(laughs)

Sandra shifts the towers of papers around, revealing a glass of wine with only a sip left, and El in the distant dark hallway--

SANDRA
(to El)
Right on time for Mister
Mom’s gourmet.

Sandra moves her plate closer,and then starts to poke at the food. The student papers isolate her from

Dave serves El and himself a plate and sits.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Find any work?

Dave and El look to each other.

DAVE
Who are you asking?

Sandra grabs another tower of papers and moves it to the floor behind her. Revealing herself to the others.

SANDRA
I didn’t expect you to find a job
so soon.

DAVE
I didn’t.

SANDRA
Right.

El begins typing on her smartphone.

Sandra reaches over to El, takes her phone and places it facedown on the table.

Made in Highland

SANDRA
Honestly. And I hate to say this. But, I don't think this dog thing is the best idea. It's not you, it's the deadbeats around here. They're scum. Grade A scum...Grade F scum rather.
(guuuulp of wine)
I don't know what I'd do to myself if anything ever happened to you.
(to Dave)
You forgot the wine.

Another glass down.

Dave retrieves the wine, and his large coffee mug. He takes a big sip of his coffee as he refills Sandra's glass to the tippy top.

DAVE
(to El)
I think she has a point, sweetie.

Sandra smiles and sips, leaning back in her seat.

DAVE
Maybe we can give her a chance?

SANDRA
(back at attention)
A chance to get kidnapped!?--
Or worse!?

DAVE
She already told three different people she'd walk their dogs for them.

SANDRA
Yeah, and what if they don't pay her? What then?

DAVE
They'll have to talk to me.

Gulp. Gulp.

Sandra clinks the glass with a fingernail to a slow tempo.

SANDRA
Two weeks probation for both of you.
(to El)
You have to be back before dinner
(MORE)

Made in Highland

SANDRA (CONT'D)
every night.
(to Dave)
If anything goes wrong...it's on you.

DAVE
What else is new?

SANDRA
Right.

Sandra dumps her food in the trash, and exits.

Dave shoots El a wink, but El's nerves frazzle.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. SCHOOL - AFTERNOON

El sits at her desk, tensed, fingers gripping the rim of the desk, a closed book in front of her. Loud tickticktick of a clock winds into her head.

The students engage in quiet work, play on their smartphones, or place their head down upon folded arms for a nap.

El checks the clock, the seconds hand of the clock slows.

She rubs her eyes, and the seconds slow down further.

Prying her hands free from her anxiety death-grip, she opens the book in front of her.

Reads a sentence--

Slams the book closed.

The clock stops moving. It tries to move forward, but every click and tick of the clock doesn't extend forward.

The clock grows fat with tension.

She takes cover under the desk: knees in chest, eyes closed, and covered with her hands.

HALLWAY

Empty school hallway, lockers line both sides of the wall.

Bell.

Made in Highland

El busts out from a classroom. Running down the hall, around and between the crowd, as the students pour out en masse.

She turns through a door

STAIRWELL

and gets caught in a long slow line.

Trying to cut through--she's rejected and forced back to wait along the slow-moving line.

DISSOLVE TO:

HOMEROOM

Chatty class. The teacher takes roll out loud. No one pays the teacher any mind.

Bell rings--

Five seconds later, El enters.

HR TEACHER
How it it possible to be late to p.m. homeroom?

Clock moves forward quickly now,
Tick
Tick
Ticking as the teacher continues to call roll.

HALLWAY

Bell Rings.

By the time El gets out of class, a crowd of students block the main exit.

El takes another route.

EXT. FOOTBALL FIELD

El runs through a stream of never-ending students running laps on the track around the football field.

She crosses to the other side of the track, and stumbles onto the field

The football team practicing.

Made in Highland

A football hits her square in the chest, knocking the wind out of her, but she catches the ball.

She sprints, ball in hand.

The team chases after her.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

El bursts in to the apartment

EL'S BEDROOM

and drops her stuff onto the floor. She checks the time.

3:38PM

She sets an alarm for two hours from now.

Changes into the workout version of her uniform, sweat-bands and all.

EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT

Behind the closed door, ALBIE, Sheen's pooch, barks and scratches and jumps onto the door.

El pulls a keychain out of her pocket, sorts through the keyring, finds what she's looking for, then opens the door.

Albie busts out and gives El some much needed affection.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY

Albie leads the way along the second story landing of the apartment complex.

COLLEGE KID'S DORM

Albie barks at Bo barking at him from behind the door.
El knocks.

ZOE (O.S.)
Hold on!

Beat.

Zoe opens up and hands over the leashed Bo.

Made in Highland

APARTMENT COMPLEX

742 Albie and Bo yank El, fighting for the lead. El enjoys being pulled around.

743 **SHARON'S APARTMENT**

744 Albie and Bo bark at BELLE, yipping right back from behind the door.

745 Knock. Knock.

746 No answer.

747 Knock. Knock.

748 KNOCK. KNOCK.

749 WALTER (late 20s) answers the door shirtless and in underwear, he's drinking a protein shake from a plastic shaker. He drops a leash on the floor and walks away still gulping down the protein without making any sort of eye contact or closing the door.

750 El attempts to leash Belle as the whole pack of the dogs engage in a playful, yet chaotic, scuffle.

751 **EXT. STREET**

752 The dogs pull El so hard her feet don't quite touch the ground--

753 Pure bliss.

754 Bo stops. The other dogs halt a bit past him.

755 El flies beyond them, and crashes into garbage bins.

756 She returns to Bo relieving himself...

757 El whips a plastic bag out of her pocket, but as soon as Bo's butt puckers up the mush squad keeps on mushing, pulling El away from her neighborly duty.

758 El fights with all her might back towards the waste, and scoops it up despite the tug-o-war.

759 **EXT. DOG PARK**

El and the dogs pull up with a skidding halt--El falls onto the ground due to the sudden stop.

Made in Highland

The park has five other dogs in the park with their owners.

El checks the time.

They fight their way through multiple gated barriers.

When inside the park, El lets the dogs loose.

El walks over to a covered area where the other dog owners congregate and chat.

As soon as she steps into their air, she clocks their faces; all of them have clammed up and look at her with disappointment.

She plays with the dogs.

DISSOLVE TO:

El checks the time.

One hour left.

She summons the dogs and leashes them.

Exiting through the barriers, Albie pulls from one side, Bo and Belle the other. This catches El off guard, and Albie gets free.

He gallops straight for a mud puddle,

dive-bombs into it.

The puddle swallows Albie, nothing but a leash lays across the watery mud.

El jumps for his leash. She can’t quite reach without falling into the puddle.

Belle runs to the edge of the puddle, ready for duty..

El tosses Belle into the puddle, leash in hand.

Belle bites down on Albie’s leash.

Bo and El pull.

Belle’s out, leash in teeth.

Albie escapes.

They shake clean. Sorta.

Made in Highland

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - ALLEY

In the back alley behind the apartment complex, the dog's leashes tied to a chainlink fence, and El hoses them down with a long green garden hose.

Somewhere near by, a loud thunderous woof.

All the other dogs answer the bark with a bark of their own, jumping to attention.

El quickly shushes them!

Gary and Jojo pass by them a bit down the alley. Gary yaps on his phone.

Jojo notices the other dogs and starts hollering.

Gary, oblivious, ignores Jojo's urge to mash chomps with the other dogs and they keep on moving down the road and out of sight.

El releases a breath of relief.

Time check. Twenty minutes.

INT. BATHROOM

El grabs enough fresh towels from the closet.

EXT. ALLEY

El dries the dogs.

As she unties the leashes from the fence, Albie starts to bark again.

El tries to shush him.

Sheen pops up behind El.

SHEEN
And a bath? I'm impressed.

El's alarm for dinner sounds off.

She hands Albie to Sheen, El slithers away with the other dogs.

SHEEN (O.S.)
What's for dinner?

El turns back confused--

Made in Highland

Sheen and Albie gone.

INT. KITCHEN - EVENING

El pulls a plate out from the microwave and joins Dave at the dinner table.

Dave takes a bite of his food...grimaces. He puts his plate back in the microwave. Yawns, and takes a big old sip from his coffee mug.

DAVE
You think I should make your--
Sandra a plate? Probably should,
right?

He fixes her a plate.

Microwave beeps.

DAVE
(walking back to the table)
Don’t tell you mom--dammit. Don’t
tell her that...

Sits back down, stirs the food, and starts chowing.

El looks up, waiting for him to finish. She taps her utensils on the table to grab his attention.

DAVE
(taking a few moments
to notice)
What was I saying?...I think I
like these frozen mashed potatoes
better than homemade. But you
can’t say that of course. Even
when they ask. You’ll see when you
grow up and get married if you’re
stupid enough to fall into that
trap. Not saying you’re stupid
obviously. Getting married is
stupid. Or...could be stupid.
Guess it just depends on who
you’re getting married to. I’m not
trying to give you the wrong idea.
I’m just stupid. And I love you,
and Sandra loves you, too. You’ll
find someone some day to take care
of you. Uh, you know, not that you
need taking care of.

Dave flings his hands in the air, and continues eating.

Made in Highland

Beat.

DAVE
Oh yeah! I almost forgot to tell you that I got you another client. Gary. The guy next door. With the pit-bull.

El recoils.

DAVE
Sweetie, money is money, right? It's not smart to turn down work.

El shakes her head 'no' furiously.

DAVE
Give me one good reason why not?

El types on her smartphone. Dave reads the text.

DAVE
I don't think that's true.

El starts typing, but ultimately decides not to send the message. She gets up from the table and dumps her plate into the garbage.

DAVE
He said he hides a key in the patio light. I have a small ladder you could use to reach it.

About to leave--

DAVE
Oh yeah, before I forget--uh, you're spending the weekend with Mom. Not your mom--obviously. My mom. Grandma.

El halts. Rapidly types. Deletes. Then composes another message.

DAVE
Sandra's aunt died and we need to go up north for the weekend.

Another message.

DAVE
How would we look if we left a sixteen year old girl home alone?

And another...

Made in Highland

DAVE
I'll ask her...but, you know how she is.

As El leaves--

DAVE
Don't forget to give her a hug when she gets home. She seemed upset on the phone.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - PARKING LOT - LATE AFTERNOON

El enters the parking lot, dogs in hand, returning from a walk.

Sandra reorganizes the trunk of the car, and then closes it before noticing El coming up on her tail. She picks up a glass of wine from the asphalt, before the dogs trample her.

El follows her to the driver's side door, the dogs all the while trying to get love from Sandra. She pushes the dogs away.

DAVE
(from within the car, in the driver's seat)
You know which buses to take?

SANDRA
We'd drop you off if it wasn't in the opposite direction.

DAVE
Mom's looking forward to--

Sandra slams the door closed.

Dave pulls out from their parking spot, waving to El. Sandra refilling her wine glass, spills some on herself, and silently freaks out on Dave.

They drive off into the distance.

El waits for them to disappear, a smile creeps onto her face, and she then ascends the flight of stairs.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - EVENING

8:00PM.

El, sitting cross-legged in front of the TV, a plate of food on her lap, laughs at a Comedy film.

DISSOLVE TO:

Made in Highland

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Midnight.

El, popcorn in lap, TV light the only light source, fingers covering her face, jumps out of her skin from a Horror flick fright.

She flicks all the lights on in the room.

Shuts down the TV.

Checks the lock on the front door.

INT. EL'S BEDROOM

El locks her bedroom door, shuts the blinds, and dives under the covers.

She ignores the multiple missed calls from Dave and Sandra on her phone.

Ignoring the messages, she scrolls through content.

Her eyes drift closed, her head nods--

Ding. She jerks awake. A voicemail.

She listens to the voicemail--Dave's muffled voice. She drifts off again, to come back to moments later.

She pulls up Dave's Mom's phone number.

INT. EL'S BEDROOM - MORNING

El wakes up, her phone's dead.

She plugs the phone into a charger, awaits for life to return to it--

A familiar dog barks, and then someone knocks on the front door.

EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

Sheen and Albie stand out front.

El opens the door, her face shifts to mortified, and tries to quickly close the door--

Made in Highland

SHEEN
Hey hey hey!
(stops the door from closing, pushes it open)
Everything okay?

El nods 'yes.'

SHEEN
Not according to your pops.

El angry instead of confused--

SHEEN
Calm down. Calm down...I don't know how he found me, but he did, and he's worried about you. He says he tried to call you like a million times.

EL becomes embarrassed.

SHEEN
Here's the deal. I never knew I needed a dog-walker until I got one, and I'm not willing to lose one just yet. So you're staying at my place until your parents get back into town, and then you're going to beg to not be grounded for an eternity.

El's purses her lips until they disappear.

SHEEN
You got an hour. See ya soon.
(walking away)
Don't make me come looking for you!

EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT - AFTERNOON

Knock. Knock.

Sheen makes her wait, but not nearly as long as last time. She bares a warm smile as she opens the door.

SHEEN
You got a key, dontcha?

Sheen hugs El who shifts into a wet noodle.

Sheen lets El go, then goes back inside like nothing ever happened.

Made in Highland

El stands frozen at the threshold, awkward.

INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT

El hears muffled barks as she stalks into the apartment.

SHEEN
In here!

El follows Sheen's voice into the

KITCHEN

Barking a bit louder, now.

SHEEN
Albie! Shut it won't ya?!
(to El)
I'm surprised he's not all over you right now...
(laughs)
Make yourself at home.

Sheen exits. El remains hovering awkwardly.

Albie's suddenly at her feet.

SHEEN (O.S.)
Yo! I said make yourself comfortable.

Sheen grabs El's backpack off of her back and hooks it onto the back of a chair.

El crouches down to Albie's level, and he licks her face.

SHEEN
Now sit down and get hungry cause we're about to eat my Florida--if not the country, if not the world--famous mac-n-cheese. Homemade. Not the boxed stuff. There ain't now powder on these here ronies. And don't tell me you ain't hungry because I remember what they serve at school.

El takes a seat and a bowl slides from the other end of the table right in front of her.

Sheen returns with another bowl for herself.

Made in Highland

SHEEN
No need to wait for me. How is it?

El holds up a mouthful on the spoon, blows off some of the heat, then gulps it down.

She chows down on the bowl.

SHEEN
What better response could a chef ask for!

El finishes her bowl, and notices Sheen playing with her food instead of eating it.

SHEEN
More?

Affirmative.

Sheen refills her bowl.

SHEEN
You walking all the mutts today?

Mhm. Soon.

SHEEN
I think I'll join you. If that's cool with you.

Sheen slides the bowl across the table.

Car alarms sounding-off appear faint and grow louder and louder.

Ding.

Sheen checks her phone.

SHEEN
Hey. I'll be right back. Help yourself to more if you want. Don't feed fatty any.
(to Albie, dog voice)
"No, no, no, I can't eat human food because then I diarrhea all over the entire apartment!"

Sheen exits.

Fat bass beats the apartment, shaking the entire structure, an earthquake of low-end.

El taps her fingers along the table fidgeting.

Made in Highland

Another spoonful...

and then El can’t help herself but to peek out the blinds behind her, and she watches Sheen get into the red race-car--

El chokes.

Then hurries to the fridge to grab some water.

As she guzzles down a drink, she looks over the polaroid splattered doors of the fridge.

Pictures are out of focus, weird angles. Partying.

The front door opens and El rushes back to her seat.

Sheen walks right past the kitchen.

Bedroom door closes. Music plays from within the bedroom.

El finishes up her bowl of food,

and cleans it in the sink.

She looks for a place to set the clean plate--

SHEEN (O.S.)
You didn’t have to do that!

Sheen grabs her full bowl from the table, dumps it into the pot, then shoves the pot into the fridge.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - A BIT LATER

El, Sheen, Albie, Belle, and Bo walk along the second story hallway of the apartment complex.

Sheen takes a bit of a stumble.

El notices, and Sheen notices El noticing.

Sheen smiles and brushes it off.

Climbing down a flight of stairs toward the ground level--

Sheen pauses on the stairs mid-descent, doubles over, leaning on the railing.

She sluggishly falls back.

SHEEN
I don’t think the food is sitting with me right.
(MORE)

Made in Highland

993 SHEEN (CONT'D)
To think my world famous Mac would betray me...I'll see you in a bit...

995 El, disappointed, watches Sheen stumble up the stairs, frozen for a few moments.

996 The dogs jerk her to life.

997 **EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - AFTERNOON [FAST FORWARD 2X]**

998 As they exit the parking lot, the dogs play and brawl, pulling El with speed and vigor.

999 They cross the street, and pull El towards the dog park.

1000 El digs her heels into the pavement, regaining control of the pooches. Instead of them walking her, she's finally doing the walking.

1001 El recrosses the other side of the street...

1002 They circle the apartment complex time and time again. With each round, another dog does its duty.

1003 El hands off the dogs to their owners.

1004 **EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT**

1005 El almost knocks--but catches herself.

1006 She pulls out her key and lets herself in.

1007 **INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT**

1008 Albie darts into the apartment excited to be home.

1009 He leads her to a closed door, and barks.

1010 El reaches for the knob, and with the slightest twist--

1011 The door blows in--air blows out with the power of the vacuum of space.

1012 El grabs onto the flapping door to hold on and grabs Albie's leash.

1013 Once the pressure stabilizes they return to the ground to peek inside the room.

Made in Highland

An idyllic paradise full of life and vitality. Birds chirp, deers prance, and rivers ebb and flow.

Albie darts off into the wilderness.

El dives into the painting after only a moment's hesitation.

INT. SHEEN'S ART ROOM

Sheen admires a freshly spray-painted canvas. A spray-can can hangs idly by Sheen's side. El, cross-legged on the floor, looks up form her sketchbook. They are surrounded by complete and in-progress paintings.

Sheen drops a fresh canvas next to the finished one.

SHEEN
Wanna give it a go?

El quickly shuts that notion down, backing away from the canvas.

Sheen takes El by the hand leading her back to the canvas, shakes a spray-can, and places it firmly in El's hand.

SHEEN
It's so easy.
You...just...need...to...push...
your...little...finger...down.

Sheen pats El's head, messing up her hair.

SHEEN
I'll be right back.

Sheen closes the door behind her as she leaves.

El's eyes shift between Sheen's masterful canvas and the blank canvas.

Perfect and...

Imperfect.

Perfect and...

Imperfect.

She raises the spray-can...

Albie watches jaws agape and lulling tongue.

El's 'little finger' every so slowly pushes down on the nozzle--

Made in Highland

The paint makes a big dot on the canvas--El recoils pulling the can back away from the canvas.

With a can in each hand, she gets into the flow, spraying shots of paint in rapid fire--

Sheen opens the door--

El quickly hits the lights, turning the room dark.

Sheen turns the lights back on.

The front of El's canvas faces the wall.

SHEEN
Pretend like I'm not even here.

Sheen fiddles with things in the closet.

El destroys her canvas, her back to Sheen.

Sheen peeks out from the closet, befuddled.

El's backpack lies on the floor, some contents spilled out, El's sketchbook.

Sheen nabs the sketchbook, and flips through it...

El coming out of her fit of self-hate, notices Sheen--her eyes grow to take up her whole face.

Sheen holds the book up high above El's head as she jumps up-and-down attempting to retrieve it.

SHEEN
(still flipping)
You've drawn the whole neighborhood, eh?
(giggling)
You got one of me?...

El bends at the knees as low as she can, for one more solid attempt at a jump, and her fingers grasp the book--

Sheen makes a break for it, opens the door, and runs down the

HALLWAY

into the

LIVING ROOM

Made in Highland

Sheen jumps onto the couch and El running after her falls on top of her, then onto the floor below.

When El goes to swipe the book one more time, Sheen's already found the page...

SHEEN
Wow...I'm really something in ink.

El shrivels, grabbing her knees into her chest.

Sheen notices--hands her the book back.

SHEEN
You got an eye...Maybe even two.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. SHEEN'S LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Lights from the loud television dance across El's and Albie's face. El lies belly down on the couch, Albie's curled up on her legs. Sheen is passed out on the floor.

INT. DINER - MORNING

Sheen leads El and Albie to a table, and they take their seats.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS approaches.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Uh, who seated you?

SHEEN
(points O.S.)
She did.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
She didn't cause if she did, <u>it</u>
(pointing to Albie)
would not be sitting in here.

SHEEN
<u>He's</u> a--uh, what'do'ya call em?

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Service dog?

SHEEN
Yup.

Made in Highland

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
Are you kidding?

SHEEN
I got the papers in the car. But do we really need to stoke the fire...
(re: EL)
This dog is the only thing keeping you alive right now. The Incredible Hulk-ess is what they call her, and that's before the prison break.

Gum-Chewer keeps her eyes on Sheen's.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
What do you want?

SHEEN
Menus.

Gum-Chewer leaves in a huff.

Sheen smiles at El.

Storms back with menus. Dumps them on the table, takes out her pad and pen and taps her toe.

Without looking at the menus:

SHEEN
Banana pancakes.

El gives a thumbs up.

SHEEN
(holding up two fingers)
Two. And waters...and a coffee. Got it?

Gum-Chewer writes the order and leaves without any eye contact.

Sheen fusses with her purse.

SHEEN
She's lucky I'm a server too. What a crank.
(beat)
What color nail polish?

El nods "no."

She dumps a few bottle of polish on the table. Deliberates over a few different options.

Made in Highland

SHEEN
(pushing three of her choices over toward El)
I think these would look good on you. Real choice.

While still nodding, she picks a color.

SHEEN
I was hoping you'd pick that one.
(beckoning for El's hand)
Gimme your hand. I bet I could get one hand done before she even brings the drinks.

Sheen paints El's fingernails on her left hand.

Gum-Chewer returns with drinks.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
You can't do that in here.

SHEEN
Why not?

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
It's policy.

SHEEN
It's policy to not allow a mom to paint her daughter's nails in the one hour per week I get to spend with her while the child services watches through the window from the parking lot?

Gum-Chewer walks away biting her lip.

SHEEN
(to El)
Other hand.

El obliges.

SHEEN
(pantomiming)
Blow.

Sheen paints the right hand.

The Gum-Chewer conspires in whispers with some compatriots across the diner.

She returns, shaking, clearly with something to say.

Made in Highland

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
If...if. If you get any of that. Any of it. Any where. You're cleaning it!

SHEEN
Why are you telling me this for? I'm a professional. If anyone is gonna get any polish anywhere it's gonna be her. So why don't you say it to my dying daughter's eyes that she needs to scrub polish off your plastic tables with her poor frail fingers.
(Sheen covers her mouth with one hand, in whispers)
Cancer.

Gum-Chewer storms off.

Sheen, not once breaking from the task, finishes the job.

SHEEN
Okay, blow on those now too. How do they look?...I'm enjoying this way too much.

In between all the blowing, El gives two thumbs up.

SHEEN
Now you're balling.

Pancakes arrive with a crash on the table. Gum-Chewer starts off--

SHEEN
Excuse me.

Gum-Chewer turns slowly...

SHEEN
Syrup, please?

Gum-Chewer walks back towards the kitchen, they wait quietly, smirking, and back she returns with some syrup.

GUM-CHEWING WAITRESS
(under breath)
You're welcome.

SHEEN
What was that?

El pours syrup on her pancakes. And just as she is about to take a bite--

Made in Highland

SHEEN
No, no, no. Sometimes you're the one spitting on people's food and sometimes your food is the food getting spat on.

Sheen places a twenty dollar bill on the table, and then with the polish, she writes: *5 Stars*.

INT./EXT. SHEEN'S CAR - MORNING [DRIVING]

Sheen and El toast their McMuffin's.

Sheen takes a bite and tosses the rest out the window.

El finished her breakfast sandwich, crumples the wrapper in her palm.

She stares out the window, softly jamming to music.

Sheen, lights a cigarette, and jams harder to the music. She sings the verse incorrectly, but once the chorus hits she knows the words.

Behind them, a cop car puts on its flashers.

SHEEN
Not again! And in the same damn place too! If it's the same cop as last time, I'm gonna flip.

Sheen reaches into her bra, pulls out something small that could fit easily into the palm of her hand--

SHEEN
Put this in your sock.

Sheen reaches over, El holds out her palm and the wrapper starts to un-crumple. El tosses the wrapper on the floor, and holds out her fresh hand.

Sheen hands it off, and without looking, El folds it into her hand, and slips it into her sock.

El holds her nails up--the polish has chipped and smudged on her middle and index finger.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT

Door opens. El exits alone with her backpack.

Made in Highland

Sheen comes out chasing after her, and grabs her from behind to give her a brief tight hug, then lets her go.

El turns around to give her a stronger and longer hug, letting go last.

APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY

El walks back home.

Peeking back, Sheen locks her door and heads over to Gary's apartment.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

El enters to quiet. No one around.

As El walks towards her bedroom, she hears the quiet arguing of Dave and Sandra.

She goes into her bedroom, and shuts the door.

DISSOLVE TO:

KITCHEN

El, Sandra, and Dave eat quietly around the kitchen table.

Dave works up the muster to speak:

DAVE
(to El)
Have a good weekend?

SANDRA
(to Dave)
A good weekend!?
(to El)
What in the Hell were you thinking? How dare you make us call you over and over and over and over while I'm trying to deal with my sisters and my father and and...and--

Sandra gulps from her wine glass.

El doesn't respond. Eyes on the food.

Dave places a hand on El's shoulder.

Made in Highland

DAVE
I really wish you would've picked up the phone and called us. Mom almost had a heart attack.
(sighs)
Looks like you girls bonded.

El consciously hides her freshly painted fingernails.

DAVE
They look nice.

SANDRA
(matter-of-fact)
It's not the best color for her.

El sits on her hands.

DAVE
(to EL)
I think you look nice.

SANDRA
Yeah, what do you know?

Dave jumps to frustration.

DAVE
A lot of things, actually,

SANDRA
Yeah?

DAVE
Yeah.

SANDRA
Like?

DAVE
Like if a color looks good on my damn daughter's hands or not.

Dave bangs a fist on the table and gets up to leave.

SANDRA
(pantomiming)
Look at me, I'm a big angry man!!!

Sandra cackles, finishes her wine, gets up from the table, grabs the bottle from the kitchen counter and as she exits.

SANDRA
This whole dog business...it's
(MORE)

Made in Highland

SANDRA (CONT'D)
over.

El jumps to her feet--

SANDRA
Don't make me repeat myself. And don't make me make it worse.

El falls back down to her chair.

Moments later, the television turns on in the living room. The volume rises until it's blasting.

El sits alone amongst half finished plates of food as the anger courses through her veins.

Gulps from a fake glass of wine. And uses her hands to mimic the incessant nagging between her elders.

She raises a fist, and brings it crashing down, halting before making contact with the table, frozen.

She pulls out her phone and navigates to Sheen's contact.

Her nail polished fingers begin to type away...

The red race-car returns. She could only barely hear it over the sound of the tv until it's right outside, idling in the parking lot.

She deletes the message before sending it, and closes her phone.

Peeking out the blinds: Frank takes the stairs three or four at a time.

He tries Sheen's door, and this time it's open. He lets himself in, and leaves the door wide open.

Soon he's back, he closes the door behind him, leaps down the whole flight of stairs, and takes off with fury screeching rubber.

El cleans the kitchen table, emptying the plates, and loading the dishwasher.

Washes and dries her hands.

Sirens.

Louder and louder and

LOUDER.

Made in Highland

Her tired and sad eyes widen.

El runs out of the kitchen.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY - NIGHT

El kicks it into high gear, running towards Sheen's apartment, fumbling for the key ring, red and blue lights make her skip in time--

Key ring goes flying and slides down the hallway--

Meeting the feet of OFFICER DARA (40s) at the head of Three Police Officers stampeding over the keys, knock them over the railing to the first floor.

El retreats.

As El sneaks around the top level, going the opposite direction as before--

The officers bust Sheen's door down.

El climbs down to the

FIRST STORY

and hides near some vegetation to watch what unfolds from below.

Vines whip around her wrists and ankles, securing her in place.

Albie darts out from the apartment, barking his head off, and finds El struggling with the lively plants.

Officer Dara walks out of the apartment, hand in a crack of her shirt Bonaparte-style. She whistles and signals for the brothers-in-blue below to hang back and cut the sound of the sirens.

The neighbors come out of their apartments one at a time to stoke their curiosity..

The vines continue to crawl up El's body, encasing her in a solid suit of plant armor.

Albie yowls.

Another set of sirens blare in the distance.

EMTs carry a stretcher up the flight of stairs.

Made in Highland

El turns her head to look away--the vines force her head forward.

She closes her eyelids--the vines force those open too.

Sound drops out.

She stares at Sheen's open and darkened doorway for an eternity. The darkness floods out from the apartment, until it blocks out her vision.

INT. EL'S BEDROOM

Black. TV plays loudly in another room.

Darkness withdraws.

El perches on the foot of her bed. Albie barks at her.

She cries.

Then she doesn't.

Then cries again.

Knock. Knock.

DAVE (O.S.)
Sweetie, you okay?...Wanna...talk?
(upon the no answer)
I figured as much.

The TV cuts out.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Congratulations, you scarred her.

DAVE (O.S.)
I didn't--

SANDRA (O.S.)
I swear to god, don't say you didn't do anything. I'm sick of hearing those words come out of your mouth.

Their bedroom door slams closed. Their argument continues albeit muffled.

DISSOLVE TO:

El and Albie asleep. Somewhere a tv still plays...

DISSOLVE TO:

Made in Highland

HALLWAY

Light from a far-off TV dance in the dark.

El's bedroom door opens; her and Albie sneak out.

LIVING ROOM

They tiptoe past Sandra asleep on the couch.

AT THE FRONT DOOR

El unlocks the bolt lock and as she slides the chain lock, the TV gets real quiet...Sandra yells--mumbles...nothing...and the TV programming returns.

El slips out.

EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

As she locks up behind her, she senses the presence of others.

GARY

locks up his apartment, picks up two large garbage bags and a overnight bag tucked in each arm, and leaves in a hurry, checking behind him--a light turns on as he passes it and he books it down a flight of stairs.

FRANK'S CAR

quietly pulls into the parking lot, its headlights off.

SECURITY CAMERAS

turn on their axis, then freeze in place, catching El in their sights.

INT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT

El freezes, forgets to breath.

Down the hall, Albie scratches at the bedroom door.

Made in Highland

KITCHEN

El finds Albie’s food bowl filled with a half-eaten meal.

HALLWAY

And walks toward the bedroom...

But can’t quite go all the way.

She places the bowl on the floor and slides it over to him.

He ignores it.

LIVING ROOM

El packs some of Albie’s toys in a crate.

KITCHEN

Retrieves Albie’s wet food from the fridge, closes the door--

And the Polaroids. Splattered across the entire fridge.

She stares at them, and now not under pressure of worrying being found out as too curious, really really stares at them.

They’re sloppily taken. Nothing’s in focus. Heads cut off. Some photos are nearly all just an entire thumb, or a soaked through polaroid now indecipherable.

Overhead lights strobe. Four-to-the-floor dance music bumps.

Young adults and older teens file into the apartment.

The fridge pops open and pushes El aside; a continuous stream of beers launch out of the fridge into the hands of the partiers.

She fights her way around the fridge and past the beercan line.

Three barely clad woman make out--Sheen breaks out from the threesome and El follows her into the

LIVING ROOM

SIDEWAYS-HAT keels over to vomit...

El slides under the arc of his vomit--

Made in Highland

On all fours she makes her way to a clearing, trying to evade being crushed by dancing feet.

Flash. Camera shutters. Gary, sitting on the sofa, slips his hand up a young girls skirt.

Flash. Camera shutters. Walter sits cross legged on the floor in a circle of a few other girls.

Sheen dances in the clearing.

Frank enters the clearing, grabs her by the arm and drags her away. Gary doesn't like this.

The crowd parts for them.

El follows in the wake of the parting.

HALLWAY

Frank and Sheen go into her bedroom, and just as El gets there the door slams. She tries to open the door, but it won't budge.

Gary drags a girl into the hallway, and throws her up against the wall, kissing her neck and as one hand crawls up and down her, he bangs on Sheen's door with his free hand.

The door opens.

SHEEN'S BEDROOM

But there's nothing in there.

Just a disturbed bed.

She pulls out her flashlight and scans the bed. Moving some sheets around she finds a few drops of blood.

Opens a bedside table drawer filled with tiny plastic baggies. She submerges her hand in them, and pulls one out. It has a bunny design on it. Another one, hearts. Another one, skulls with crossbones.

INT. EL'S BEDROOM - MORNING

El stares out the window into the sunlight.

Knocks on the door.

SANDRA (O.S.)
Need a ride?

Made in Highland

Moments later the front door closes.

Another knock on the door.

DAVE (O.S.)
Heading to Home Depot. Do you want me to drive you to school?

KITCHEN - LATER THAT MORNING

El robotically opens her textbook and notebook at the kitchen table.

She retrieves a pencil, and places the tip on the page

Dave enters, bags in hand. He places them on the table, then sets up a pot of coffee.

Dave leaves the kitchen, and turns the TV on in the living room.

El whips out her headphones and plugging them in--

BEEP BEEP BEEP disrupts her--

Out the blinds a large truck carrying a dumpster is guided by brothers Mylo and ALEK (30s) and dropped off into the courtyard below.

Dave returns to the kitchen (wearing stained clothes).

El tries to ignore him as he grabs a cup of coffee and a bowl of cereal, and chows down at the table. The news still overpowers the music of her earbuds.

Dave says something to her she can’t hear, she pulls out her earbuds, “what?”

DAVE
I was saying you’re very studious.

She puts her earbud back in. And he talks again...

Earbud out, “what?”

DAVE
I was saying that I’m impressed.
If I was you, I’d be grieving.
Inconsolable.

Back to work.

Dave gobbles the bowl down. Cleans up, deposits the bowl in the sink, and before he leaves--

Made in Highland

El pre takes her earbud out. Dave smiles.

DAVE
(ruffling through a bag, finds gloves, detaches them from each other)
Don't work too hard. If you need me, I'll be right--I'm working near by. So text me if you need me. I'll see you in a bit.

Dave exits.

El tries to refocus on her homework. But the tv...it's so damn loud.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
...another breaking story. Another criss. But the same plague claiming our young and old alike.

LIVING ROOM

El searches for the tv remote.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
South Florida continues to be a hotbed affected by the opioid epidemic.

She finds the remote in a cushion crack.

ANCHOR (O.S.)
The how and why of our area's particular involvement--coming up.

She points the remote at the tv.

ANCHOR
But first--

Finger on the trigger.

ANCHOR
Another victim of the perpetual tragedy, Frank Lopez, or at-red-frank-five-six-six. Lost his wife to be just last night, and when we return he'll tell us just how hard the past eight hours have been for him--
(smiles)
after this.

Made in Highland

El takes a crashing sit.

She stares idly at the commercials

and they blur

as the wheels in her brain stop turning.

ANCHOR
And we're back. If you've been watching we've been chronicling the opioid epidemic in South Florida. Last night, a husband to be, finds his wife dead...

Video evidence of that volatile relationship between Frank and Sheen begins to play on screen.

ANCHOR
He says, quote, It was like reality tv. We were intentionally trying to create drama--

Click. TV shuts down.

Bang! Clang! Metal! Thunk!

Outside, through the blinds, El watches Alek dump some furniture from the second floor into the dumpster below.

Followed by Dave and Mylo carrying a larger piece of Sheen's art.

El ricochets out of the house.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - SECOND STORY

She Sonic-the-Hedgehogs over to Sheen's.

EXT. SHEEN'S APARTMENT

Dave exits, painting in hand, sees El rushing over.

DAVE
I told you to text if you need me!...You don't want to see this.

El grabs the painting out of his hands. And as Mylo files out next, she grabs the painting he's holding too.

Alek exits, and she tries to grab the painting he is holding too, but he easily holds it way above her head.

Made in Highland

MYLO
Sweetie, what do you think you are doing?!

El attacks Alek like a feral animal, but he deters her just by holding a hand up.

MYLO
Ah, yes. You are the brat from before.

DAVE
Sorry, she's my daughter. She doesn't exactly talk.

Dave grabs her off of Alek's back.

MYLO
Control your brat, or you are gonna be out work, buddy.
(pointing to the cameras everywhere)
Don't make me call Julian.

DAVE
No, no. Of course not.

El, two paintings recovered and tucked under arms, breathing heavy, stands behind Dave.

MYLO
Listen and listen with your little girl ears very good, and you listen too poppa.
(clears throat)
All this trash
(signals to Alek to toss the painting)
is our trash now. And me and my family, we like when trash lies with trash. So please, throw out the garbage in your arms. Or. You and your daddy can go home together right now. Bye bye.

El doesn't hesitate. About to toss them--

DAVE
(to El)
Stop.
(to Alek)
Have you heard the saying, "one man's trash is another...girls's treasure"?

Made in Highland

MYLO
...

DAVE
How much do you want?

MYLO
A days pay.

DAVE
Deal.

Dave signals for her to go. She starts off to go.

MYLO
Hold it.
(she stops)
If they are treasure than indeed a day's pay is a bargain for both. The deal is...a day's pay for one.

El tosses one without looking at either of them at Mylo's feet and walks away. Mylo smiles and waves as she leaves.

MYLO (O.S.)
(to Dave)
Back to work! And cheer up, you're not the lucky owner of fine art. Now you can add 'investor' to your resume.

EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

Before El goes back inside, she turns back to check on Dave.

Alek shackles him in chains.

INT. EL'S BEDROOM

Phone rings somewhere far off. El finds a place for the picture. She fights off tears.

LIVING ROOM

Phone continues to ring, as El secures Albie to his leash.

EXT. BUSY STREET - AFTERNOON

El bags ands ties a second bag of waste. Albie, Bo, and Belle in tow, but then--

Made in Highland

Belle slips out El's hand and runs straight for the busy road.

Belle turns into a statue as a car speeds right for her, honking its horn.

El and poo crew run, and scoop her up, crossing to the other side of the road.

On the other side, El raises her arm to scold Belle, and Belle cowers and whimpers in fear peeing herself.

El soundlessly sobs.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - EVENING

The whole family back together at last. Dave moans periodically as though he had a very very hard day's work.

SANDRA
Did they say how much they were paying you?

DAVE
No.

SANDRA
Did you ask?

DAVE
I'm sure it'll be worth it. They have me painting the next two days. By myself, I think, so I could turn it into three days if I try.

SANDRA
So you could be working for one dollar an hour and you'd have no clue. They don't even pay workers where they're from.

DAVE
Beggars can't be choosers.

SANDRA
You'd think a forty year old man--

DAVE
Don't round up. Thirty eight.

Made in Highland

SANDRA
Rent’s due next Wednesday. Are you going to be able to chip in so who knows, maybe I could have some money for myself and who knows maybe treat myself to a new outfit or a pedicure?

DAVE
Yeah.

SANDRA
(to El)
Why weren’t you in school?

DAVE
She wasn’t feeling good.

SANDRA
I asked her. You were feeling good enough to go walk your dogs. Sweetie, don’t break yourself up over someone like her. She’s no good.

El gets up to go...

SANDRA
Make sure you’re in school tomorrow, and, uh...
(clears throat)

Dave resists the signal.

She clears her throat again.

El stands, lip bleeding from biting it, fists clenched.

Dave continues his resistance.

SANDRA
The dog’s got to go. It’s my sinuses.

El stomps and silently screams.

SANDRA
Oh, calm down. I’m not saying tonight. Within the week try and find him and home.

Made in Highland

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

Two indistinguishable RIOT GUARDS come through the door, grab El by her armpits, and drag her out.

INT. GUIDANCE COUNSELOR'S OFFICE

The Riot Guards lay her down forcefully on a chaise lounge chair then take their position at the door.

Light clicks, a tiny lamp, just barely lights the COUNSELOR (80s) sitting at her desk behind El.

COUNSELOR
Your dad asked for me to ask you here. He said you needed someone to talk to. Lets see if we can get you to open up. What ails you, child?

El turns around to face the Counselor.

COUNSELOR
Do not look at me! Face the other way.

El reaches into her pocket for her cards. A long spider-leg with a human-hand on the end reaches forward and rips the cards from El. They rain down on her.

COUNSELOR
No no no. None of that silly childish nonsense. This is grown up time.

El opens her backpack to take out a pad, another spider hand pulls that away from her as well.

El peeks over the chaise lounge, the Counselor grows angry:

COUNSELOR
I don't think you understand. We want to hear your vocal cords and we want to hear them immediately. Now, there has been a sneaking suspicion around here, suspicions, if I had to wager, also held by your parents, that this whole not talking thing is
(MORE)

Made in Highland

COUNSELOR (CONT'D)
(with each word sheds her clothing and grows and grows, eight spider arms darting from each side)
one. big. act.

The Counselor now hovers over her, and slowly moves closer. El claws at her own throat, she can't breathe.

COUNSELOR
Now listen and listen well. Nobody respects a liar and a fake. Now give up this immature games and talk like a human. We spoke with your doctor, no physical ailments. Let me ask you a very important question: where do you plan on going to college? And into what field? I'll have you know, not many industries seek out or have outreach programs for liars. Lets look at your file...
(a leg retrieves El's file)
I have a few options for you here.
(holds the file up to El's face)
And since you can't talk, why don't you point at the one you're interested in! Like an animal!

Someone knocks on the door.

COUNSELOR
I'm busy! Come back later!

El slips out from under her--

Runs--

COUNSELOR
Stop her!!!

Riot Guard One runs toward her,

bending down to try and bear hug her,

she uses his knee as a launching pad,

and then face as a final boost,

hops over the other guard and

dives through the door's glass window and into her

Made in Highland

INT. EL'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Night prowler outfit.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

El tiptoes past Sandra asleep on the couch.

As she unlocks the door--

Dave stumbles out from the bedroom wiping the sleep form his eyes.

El ducks into the

KITCHEN

and slides under the table.

Dave enters, clicks on the light, pours himself a glass of water and

gulp
gulp
gulp.

Lights off, shuffles out, and the bedroom door closes.

As El slides out, Sandra stumbled towards her, so she retreats back under the table.

Sandra pours herself a drink, and sips it as she returns to the couch,

El waits awhile...

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. DRIVEWAY - NIGHT

Rideshare pulls up a driveway passing a massive opulent water fountain and trees decorated with Christmas lights.

Road goes on

and on

further

and further from civilization.

Fog grows thicker.

Made in Highland

1615 In the distance a flame.

1616 **EXT. GUARDHOUSE**

1617 Guardhouse fixed before a river moat. Stone Walls too high to see behind. A retracted four-story steel bridge.

1618 Rideshare stops just before the Guardhouse. El gets exits, and the car shrieks off.

1619 At the guardhouse, a masked and machine-gun wielding MOAT GUARD.

1620 Moat bridge lowers.

1621 Very

1622 slowly.

1623 Hummer pulls onto the bridge as it drops.

1624 **BRIDGE**

1625 She walks over to the Hummer, and its rear passenger door pops open, knocking her off the bridge and serenading her with Classical Opera music.

1626 She hangs onto the side of door, and using whatever muscles she has, tries to pull herself up--

1627 Her arms give, and she loses one hand for a moment, before regaining her handling.

1628 Below, a dark still river filled with floating red pairs of eyes.

1629 A large, leather-gloved hand from within the car grabs her by the wrist, and lifts her with ease into the backseat of the car.

1630 **INT./EXT. HUMMER**

1631 Two leather hands grip the wheel.

1632 El buckles up, and tries to catch her breath.

1633 The masked-driver, Alek, turns his head ever so slightly in El's direction.

1634 She realizes the passenger door is open, and gently closes the door.

Made in Highland

Alek zips off.

1636 The fortress is far off in the distance. The car careens along a single path, vicious jungle on both sides threaten to swallow the car whole.

1637 Jungle vegetation lets out onto a long bridge with two banks of moonlit swamp on both sides--the light ignites the eyes of a thousand hungry alligators.

1638 SKREEECH!

1639 Car halts.

1640 Alek turns on the brights--

1641 Twenty-foot Momma-Gator simmers thirty feet ahead.

1642 Alek hops out of the car...

1643 Momma-Gator comes to life, moving and ready to strike.

1644 Alek doesn’t hesitate, he advances on the M-G.

1645 As the M-G cocks its tail about to launch in to a death spin--

1646 Alek draws a handgun from his back and--

1647 El closes her eyes and ears...But she can still hear the unloading of 10 rounds.

1648 Alek gets back into the car, kicks the vehicle into high gear.

1649 El, brave enough to look again as they pull up to another four story gate--

1650 It opens inwards as they speed through.

1651 **EXT. CHATEAU - NIGHT**

1652 The late-1800 Eastern European Chateau eclipses the Hummer as the vehicle speeds along its perimeter.

1653 Finally, at the end of the Chateau, Alek turns right down a stoned driveway.

1654 Fifteen KGB OFFICERS, armed with AK47s, hike by amidst a training protocol.

1655 Twenty sports cars line the expansive, circular driveway.

1656 Alek halts the Hummer before the arched front door.

Made in Highland

INT. CHATEAU FOYER

El, immersed darkness, taps her hand along a stone wall, and her footsteps reverberate and echo in what sounds like a large cathedral.

El trips, and a metal object CLANGS onto the floor--

The sound of the falling object echoes and its feedback becomes overwhelming.

A bright blinding light--

Over head, a massive and eccentric iron chandelier's candles illuminates a stone dome painted in religious idols.

JULIA (20s) appears at the top of the grand staircase in long and spilling robes. She descends, a halo hovers around her head.

The halo around her head fades to a crown of thorns.

El, on her hands and knees, backs away from Julia.

Julia cups El's cheeks and El involuntarily stands.

JULIA
Look at you.

They lock eyes in a long silence. Julia's smile widens, and El cowers.

JULIA
Let's eat.

JULIA'S DINING ROOM

Two empty seats in the middle of a long wooden ornate table dressed with empty expensive silverware. Ten Barely-Clad woman Apostles nervously sit on their hands to each side of the two-empty chairs.

Julia pulls the true middle seat out for El to sit. And takes the other empty chair next to her.

As Julia sits, the room comes to life with dull chatter.

JULIA
We do this night to night, every night. Except when we go out...Free to say what we want, dress how we want.
(MORE)

Made in Highland

JULIA (CONT'D)
(Laughs)
Pretty simple actually.

Julia stirs a wooden spoon in the water of a metallic pitcher, then pours the fluid into a wine-glass before El.

El reaches for the wine-glass, and holds it in her lap, grasping the stem with both hands, she nervously twirls it.

JULIA
(guides the glass to El's lips)
Drink.

El takes a small sip, and gagging on the water she.pulls the glass away from her mouth.

JULIA
Driiiink.
(pushes the glass into El's mouth, and forces her to down the entire glass with a manicured fingertip)
A little bitter.

El recoils from the foul-tasting water.

Julia finishes all the fluid from her own glass in a delicate sip.

JULIA
(licks her lips)
But you get used to it.

El sits tightly-wound in her chair, grasping the rim of the seat with her hands.

JULIA
We don't normally get to dinner.
No one gets hungry.

Julia grabs El's plate, and flings it across the room.

She laughs for three tight seconds. Then slaps the thigh of the girl next to her.

The girl gets up, removes the robes from Julia's shoulders, and

massages her back.

JULIA
It's impressive, no?...All of this, I've made it.
(MORE)

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JULIA (CONT'D)
My brothers are here and taken care of. The idiots that they are. Momma's taken care of...A successful importing and exporting business. It feels so good to be able to accomplish tenfold what when at one-fold was wildly thought of as out of my capabilities.

Julia refills their wine glasses.

JULIA
Tell me--did you ever get your head stuck in between the railings of that place?...little Chad ever try and play doctor with you?...It's the little differences that I've noticed the most.

Julia sips from her glass, no longer concerned with whether or not El drinks hers.

JULIA
Is it true that you get fifty presents on Christmas? Ha!

El can't help but feel wonderful. Her pupils dilate, the lids close. All the tension releases from her body.

Julia wraps El's fingers around the wineglass. El takes small sips.

JULIA
My father said to me, when I was smaller than you, before my momma stopped giving him children--he said: I'm dying...I'm dying and I wanted a boy...every father does. But tis not what God allowed so I have to teach a girl instead.

UDA (20s) whispers into Julia's ear.

UDA
Tell us her name!

PETRA (20s) materializes from behind El's chair, hissing. She runs her fingertips up and down El's forearm.

PETRA
Yes!

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CHORUS
Tell us her name! Tell us her name!

El smiles.

JULIA
It’s her name to give.

The rest of the girls surround El, and caress her arms and legs. They run their hands through her hair.

JULIA
She doesn’t need a name here.

El laughs with no regard.

The laugh slides into a sloppy giggle.

El loses control of her eyelids, they keep falling, and as they do all falls black.

El slithers amongst writhing vines, she doesn’t fight the tendrils enveloping her entire body.

She experiences bliss for the first time; a careless bliss.

JULIA
In most ways, we’re glad she’s dead.

Somewhere far off an orchestra of cries, shouts, groans, and moans grows louder.

JULIA
She helped you stand out...She brought you to us.

Light from screens dance across El’s face. She forces her eyes open.

With all of her might she tries to push away from whatever videos she sees before her, but The Apostles hold her still.

JULIA
However, you’ve stuck your little nose in places it did not belong.

The sound from the videos cut out. The apostles disappear.

El faces a bay of screens from floor to ceiling. Each screen is tuned into a different camera angle from El’s apartment complex.

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JULIA
What were those dates you said you were curious about again?...Yes, of course, you did not say anything.

All screens tune to one feed: El's front door: Sandra asleep on the couch: Dave sitting in the dark kitchen, staring at the wall: El's bedroom, Albie asleep on her bed.

JULIA'S BEDROOM (ON THE SCREENS)

The Apostles, singing, light an ungodly amount of candles around a red-velvet bed with wrought-iron bed-posts.

JULIA
Tell me, how much do you think you're worth?

El launches out of her seat--

Large, leather-gloved hands grab her shoulders. Alek locks her in a bear-hug. As she opens her mouth to scream, he stifles it with his palm.

El fights for a moment, then quickly submits.

JULIA
We will find out.

Julia flicks her finger and Alek knows what to do and does it.

LONG WINDING STAIRCASE

Alek carries El up the spiral stone staircase. El, her body limp, and her eyes searching for a way out--

Alek huffs, a bit out of breath.

His foot misses a step, his shin slams into stair nosing, and he thrusts one arm out to catch them from falling.

One leathered-gloved hand remains covering El's jaw--

She opens her chomps and bites into Alek's hand with all of might.

Alek winces in pain, and they slide down the stairs a few steps before he catches them again--

As he frees his hand from the glove, his flesh RIPS.

Blood pours down his hand and forearm.

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El spins around, bloody glove still in her mouth, on higher-ground...

She lifts a knee to her chest...and kicks him.

He falls onto his back and tumbles down the stairs and out of sight.

El takes the stairs down two-at-a-time.

At the bottom of the staircase,

Awaits no Alek, live or dead.

CHATEAU FOYER

Torso crushing four-to-the-floor 808 kicks send seismic waves through the landscape, making everything shake and come undone. Strobe lights stutter every movement.

The bass beats El from all directions,

She finds a door--

Blue light floods out...

Two BOUNCERS block the entrance of what looks like a super happening chick-only night club.

BOUNCER
In or out?

The OTHER BOUNCER holds up two hands, a different baggie in each palm.

El stumbles backward, the door slides closed.

Back in the strobe maze...

Crawling--

Another door.

Bright white blinding light!
Flashes
And a scream.
Bare Legs.
A cry for help!
Duct tape.
Metal tools.

She slams the door closed!

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El falls back onto the floor, she slams her fists into the ground.

She crawls back...

To wherever she thinks the front door might be...

EXT. CHATEAU - NIGHT

El ducks around the line of expensive vehicles--

a dozen Guards jog by.

SWAMP

El peeks down the eternal wooden bridge. The moon sits at the other end of the bridge taunting her.

She runs for the moon.

Her knees pumping into her stomach.

She runs

And runs--

But the moon stays ever distant, fixed in its one spot.

Behind her a siren cries.

El turns back, and she hasn’t moved from where she started.

She surveys her surroundings. There are search parties actively looking for her.

In the bridge, a missing rail-post. El approaches the gap in the rail.

BRIDGE RAIL OPENING

The bridge-post has spikes running up and down, creating a ladder. At the bottom a muddy grass area running off into the swamp.

El spots a small flat-bottom motor-less boat.

She climbs down the post.

Kicks the boat off the bank, and dives in. She searches for an oar...

red eyes open all around her.

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No oar turns up.

It's left behind on the bank, where now a group of gators all dive into the water from.

El floats in the water, hungry animals all around her.

She lies back, crosses her arms, and stares at the moon...

Blissful peace.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. RIVER - MORNING

Running water.

El wakes up...

Floating parallel to a busy highway on both sides.

DISSOLVE TO:

RIVERBANK

El's boat crashes against the bank. She hops out.

DISSOLVE TO:

STREET

El texts someone.

LATER

A car pulls up.

INT./EXT. DAVE'S CAR [DRIVING]

Drive home silently.

PULLING INTO THE PARKING LOT BACK HOME

DAVE
You know I have to tell her.

They get out of the car.

El hurries around and gives Dave a hug.

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INT./EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - DAY

El meanders to the bus stop, waits, rides, gets off, walks to school, responds to attendance, math class, history, English, lunch, bathroom, recess, biology, homeroom.

EXT. SCHOOL - AFTERNOON

School bell rings...

Doors spread open and the student body bustles out.

El patiently works her way, staying in line, waiting her turn.

She decides not to get on the bus, walks around the bus, and crosses the street.

Gunfire sprays.

El knows what's what...

As she turns around an old revolver gun slides into her feet.

EXT. OLD WEST TOWN SQUARE - HIGH NOON

Not far away and closing the gap, an armed Mia, her gang, and the rest of the school.

MIA
(gesturing to the tossed revolver)
Go on.

El picks it up. Examines it. Cocks it.

EMILY (O.S.)
No. This is stupid!

El starts towards Mia...

MIA
Stay there!

El advances, tosses the gun aside.

MIA
I said--

Mia unloads her weapon into El. But that can't stop El now.

The gap between them whisperable--Mia's gun in El's face.

Mia fingers the trigger--

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Emily knocks Mia's gun-wielding hand and the loosed bullet eats gravel.

El wraps her arms around the stunned Mia.

Crowd gasps.

Mia resists. And for a second, just one, gives in...

El lets go, and does not linger. She exits.

INT. BUS

Hugh gets on the bus and does his whole routine.

Once settled, it takes a minute for him to notice her.

He waves.

She waves back.

"Come on over," he gestures.

EXT. STREET

Hugh, bags in hand, walking slowly. El takes great pleasure in moving around, and surpassing, him.

HUGH
How rude.

She continues to make the gap between them.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

Leashes Albie.

EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS

Jeannie doesn't open her door. Neither does Walter...

Zoe, nor the Boys answer...

El walks Albie. They take their time.

El receives a text.
Ignores it.

Continues the walk.

Another text, which she thus ignores.

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The soothing walk continues. Ending on its natural conclusion. Not a moment earlier.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - EVENING

El ascends the stairs.

EXT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

Officer Dara, Hugh, Frank, Gary, and the rest of the neighborhood crowd outside of the front door.

INT. SANDRA'S APARTMENT

El comes into the house, the crowd behind her.

SANDRA (O.S.)
(hearing the front door open)
Where have you been? You know the rule and you still missed dinner. You made us wait. You didn't answer our texts. For all we knew, you could've been dead.

LIVING ROOM

Sandra and Dave sit in the same almost-touching couches, but very far apart, not even nearly touching.

SANDRA
Do you have any idea--

Crowd files in behind El.

DAVE
Should I make hour d'oeuvres?

INT. COURTROOM

OFFICER DARA
Presiding over this hearing is the Honorable Judge Dara. Ladies and gentleman, please rise.

JUDGE DARA enters the courtroom in judge clothes, and takes her seat behind the bench.

JURY of plainclothes DARAs file in, and take their seats in the jury box.

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JUDGE DARA
Prosecutor Dara, your opening remarks, ma'am.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Thank you, your honor.

PROSECUTOR DARA stands from behind her desk, and approaches the Jury..

PROSECUTOR DARA
Ladies and gentleman of the jury, the Defendant has caused all sorts of trouble. Evidence and testimonies will prove that the Defendant is a disturber of the peace, a vigilante, and most of all, and most importantly a little girl who needs to learn her place in this world. The state is certain that a guilty conviction on multiple counts: one libel, two disturbing a crime scene, three, not respecting the elders or the law, four, not going to church and being a good Christian, and five, not responding to her parents in a timely matter. With your help, ladies and gentleman of the jury, we can really teach this child a lesson. Thank you. That's all your honor.
(returns to behind her desk.

JUDGE DARA
Will the State be going after the maximum sentence?

PROSECUTOR DARA
The State hopes to get her to drop the whole not talking act, your honor.

JUDGE DARA
Maximum sentence noted.
(to El)
And the defense?

El unsure, freezes.

JUDGE DARA
Miss?

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Stutters as she stands up from her seat, approaches the Jury box with her hands in her pocket, pulls out her deck of cards, and sifts through them, pulls one out and hands it to the Jury.

FIRST JUROR takes it, makes note, hands it down the line. And so on and so forth. Waves of concern, or snooty indifference, but mainly suspicion, wash over them.

On the way back to her seat, she stops in front of the Judge and bows, then quickly retreats back to her seat.

LAST JUROR hands the card to OFFICER DARA. She walks it over to the judge, peeks, rolls eyes, and hands it over.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Objection, your honor! Secrets, secrets, are no fun, unless you share with everyone!

JUDGE DARA
Sustained!--Er, overruled...
(reading the card, rolls eyes)
Let the record show that the card the Defendant handed to the jurors has a hand-written message reading: 'it wasn't me.'
(to El)
Very lovely handwriting. You plea not guilty?

El darts to a stand, both hands on the desk, nodding "YES!"

Crowd murmurs.

JUDGE DARA
This won't play well to our adult demographic.

El sits back down, not defeated.

JUDGE DARA
Counsellor, your first witness.

PROSECUTOR DARA
The State calls Hugh and Barb as its first witness.

Hugh approaches the stand, hacking up a lung.

HUGH
Barb, couldn't make it, and she wanted me to apologize, your honor.

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JUDGE DARA
(reaching over the bench to pat him on the back)
That's quite alright. Thanks for being here. We'll get you home soon.

HUGH
(pulls a folded piece of paper out of a pocket)
I do have her note however on the matters at hand.

PROSECUTOR DARA
That won't be necessary.

HUGH
You tell her that.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Sir, when did you first become aware of the Defendant's existence?

HUGH
Aware?...They adopted five four eight, I think eight or nine years ago. It had to be eight cause my prostrate went into remission. The cancer, you know.

PROSECUTOR DARA
And did the parents tell you they adopted her?

HUGH
No, they didn't. But you don't give birth to an eight year old, do you?

PROSECUTOR DARA
No.

HUGH
This was all in my wife's letter by the way.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Alright, sir, so when did you realize she was a little brat?

HUGH
I'd say about three hours ago.

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PROSECUTOR DARA
Okay, take whatever time you need, sir, but can you walk us through it?

HUGH
I'm an old man--

PROSECUTOR DARA
Yes...go on...

HUGH
And I'm walking to the bus stop with two arms full of groceries. The cold-cuts are getting squashed, the rye beyond repair. I made a sandwich it was mush. The liverwurst, let me tell you something, Jaron, the colored boy, cuts my wife perfect slices of liverwurst.

PROSECUTOR DARA
When does the defendant come into this?

HUGH
Sure sure sure. I'm carrying a million bags, walking up hill, and I'm waiting for the bus. I think I'm going to topple over at this point. So I'm waiting and I'm waiting and as the bus finally pulls up, I get on, of course, and I notice her sitting on the bus sitting their reading.

Crowd murmurs.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Reading?

HUGH
Reading. Other times I've seen her doodling--

Crowd gasps. Judge Darryl bangs her judge-hammer.

JUDGE DARA
Order. Order.

HUGH
And so, of course, knowing all the while in my head that since she is
(MORE)

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HUGH (CONT'D)
young and her time is much less important than mine, I ask her for help.

PROSECUTOR DARA
But she doesn't--
(slamming the desk)
does she!?

HUGH
No, she doesn't. That's what is so very concerning. She has always said yes before with out any lip. Just like that she declines me, flips like a light switch.

PROSECUTOR DARA
What were the defendants words when you, a veryveryveryvery very old man, asked for the child's help?

HUGH
"No."

Prosecutor DARA lets it sink in.

PROSECUTOR DARA
No, ladies and gentleman. No. This is the type of person who thinks she could say no. Imagine a world...
(to Judge)
That'll be all your honor.

JUDGE DARA
(to El)
Defense, your witness.
(sotto voce, to Officer Dara)
Though, I don't see the point.

Judge and Officer laugh to themselves. Crowd laughs after them, but at what, they're not sure.

El stands up, nods "No!"

JUDGE DARA
(to Hugh)
You're dismissed. Send your wife our regards.

Hugh, talking under his breath, grumbling, exits.

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JUDGE DARA
Your next witness?

PROSECUTOR DARA
The State calls Jeannie, local baker, and another character witness.

JUDGE DARA
Another character witness?

PROSECUTOR DARA
Another character witness.

JUDGE DARA
Why?

PROSECUTOR DARA
The State is building an impenetrable case by first assassinating the Defense's character.

JUDGE DARA
Sure, but don't you think we've all seen all we need to see in that department?

....

JUDGE DARA
Fine.
(to Jeannie)
From your seat then Jeannie, why don't you stand up and tell us what you don't like about the Defendant?

El turns around from her seat to peek through the crowd. JEANNIE (50s), stands up proudly.

JEANNIE
Your honor, I am a holy woman, as I am sure you are a holy man, and anyone of good character goes to church. I have been trying to get the child to come back with me to Sunday mass for the past month.

JUDGE DARA
(to Prosecutor)
Anything?

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PROSECUTOR DARA
I'm good.

JUDGE DARA
(to El)
Any questions?

Nope...

JUDGE DARA
(to Jeannie)
Thank you, please be seated.
(to Prosecutor)
Counsellor, let's keep this thing rolling. Next witness?

PROSECUTOR DARA
Your honor, will the State be permitted to call the witnesses it sees fit or will the court continue to interfere?

JUDGE DARA
Counsellor, you and I both know, we all want to get to the juicy stuff.

Prosecution reviews documents.

PROSECUTOR DARA
State calls for a short recess in order to trim the fat from the the witness list.

INT. COURT HALLWAY

Prosecution dismisses Frank, Gary, and Walter.

Down the hall, El throws a silent tantrum.

DAVE
I was wondering why they were even here.

0.0

INT. COURTROOM

PROSECUTOR DARA
State calls...
(spinning around and points)
the Reporter!

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The REPORTER (30s) sat in the last bench, in the shadows, notebook and pencil out. She stops writing and makes her way to the bench.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Missus--

REPORTER
Miss.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Missus?

REPORTER
...miss...

PROSECUTOR DARA
Miss Reporter. How long ago did the defendant reach out to you?

REPORTER
That is private information.

PROSECUTOR DARA
How did she contact you?

REPORTER
Private.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Object, your honor! Everything can’t be private. We must know the truth!

JUDGE DARA
Miss Reporter, please answer the questions to the best of your ability.

REPORTER
Okay.

PROSECUTOR DARA
What was the content of the message or messages?

REPORTER
Confidential.

PROSECUTOR DARA
(slamming desk)
Were these photos solicited?

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REPORTER
Who said anything about photos?

PROSECUTOR DARA
Your honor, the State asks that the court forces Missus Reporter to read aloud to the good people of the jury the messages back and forth between the Defendant and Miss Reporter.

JUDGE DARA
Missus--

REPORTER
Miss.

JUDGE DARA
Miss...Reporter, we implore you to relay the content the defendant shared with you.

REPORTER
Not without a subpoena.

PROSECUTOR DARA
So let me get this straight!
(spittle flies from his mouth, he’s losing it)
You receive unsolicited content talking about murder and conspiracy and making wild accusations from a fourteen your old girl and your first instinct is not to contact the police but to write an op-ed about it masquerading as fact?!?!

REPORTER
What’s your question?

PROSECUTOR DARA
Objection, your honor. The question was clear.

JUDGE DARA
Sustained. The question was clear.

REPORTER
Can you repeat the question please?

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PROSECUTOR DARA
(pleading)
Your honor?

JUDGE DARA
Answer the question.

REPORTER
What is the question?

JUDGE DARA
(to Court Stenographer Dara)
Read the question back, please.

COURT STENOGRAPHER DARA looks through the notes...

STENOGRAPHER DARA
I believe the question as posed was 'what is wrong with you?'

REPORTER
I don't believe that's what was asked.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Those were my exact words!

REPORTER
Did any of you read the article?

El slams her fist onto the desk.

Shock catches like wildfire and spreads through the crowd.

JUDGE DARA
What do you object to?

PROSECUTOR DARA
Objection! I object her objection!

JUDGE DARA
Overruled.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Your honor, the State has the right to procure an answer from its star witness in this capacity--

Reporter seems to be missing.

JUDGE DARA
Prosecution, next witness?

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PROSECUTOR DARA
State calls the Defendant.

No.

JUDGE DARA
Please approach the stand.

No.

PROSECUTOR DARA
The State doesn't mind questioning the brat right where she stews.

DAVE
Hey! Go easy on her!

SANDRA
(hushed)
Sit down!

PROSECUTOR DARA
Why do you think it was appropriate to meddle in the state's affairs?

No.

PROSECUTOR DARA
Breaking and entering. Disturbing a crime scene.

DAVE
Where's the proof?!

PROSECUTOR DARA
(turning to Dave)
Did you sleep through the testimonies?

JUDGE DARA
Order!

SANDRA
(to Dave, yanking on his arm)
I said sit down!

Cut to Black. Door slams.

INT. SANDRA'S LIVING ROOM - RIGHT BEFORE SUNSET

El and Sandra face off.

Dave returns into the living room...

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He sits next to El.

SANDRA
He
(pointing to Albie)
needs to be gone by tomorrow.

Dave puts his hand on El's shoulder, sighs, and just as he turns to say--

El stops him, urging him aside, she sits up...

She mouths--*No*.

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